

Italian fontina and roasted garlic polenta with creamy tomato sauce

Butter, Italian fontina cheese, and roasted garlic are superb additions to polenta. I stir the cornmeal above and beyond in this recipe to make sure it as **creamy** as possible. Freshly grated Parmesan broiled on top perfects the visual. Serve as suggested with the Creamy Tomato Sauce that follows or soft, simply topped with grated Parmesan cheese.

1 recipe Basic Polenta (page 216)

2 tablespoons butter

6 garlic cloves, roasted and mashed into a paste*

1 tablespoon maple syrup

3 ounces Italian fontina cheese, cut into small chunks [90g]

Salt and freshly ground pepper

3 tablespoons freshly grated Parmesan cheese

Creamy Tomato Sauce (recipe follows)

1. Prepare the Basic Polenta recipe and remove from the heat. **Stir** in the butter, roasted garlic, and maple syrup until well blended. Then stir in the fontina, mixing until the cheese is completely melted. Season generously with salt and pepper.
2. **Pour** into a medium-size oiled glass baking dish. This could be a 7 by 10 inch [18 by 25cm] rectangular dish, a 9-inch square [23-cm] or even a 10-inch [25-cm] pie dish. Sprinkle the Parmesan cheese over the polenta and let cool completely, at least 2 hours.

* To roast garlic: Preheat the oven to 300° to 325°F [150° to 160°C]. Skin the garlic cloves and cut off the hard bits on the ends. (It's okay if the cloves get crushed while you peel the skin off them.) Coat the garlic with olive oil and cook in a covered baking dish for 30 to 40 minutes, or until lightly browned and very soft. You may toss them once or so while they are cooking.

3. Before serving, place under a hot broiler for 1 or 2 minutes, or until lightly browned on top. Watch carefully, as polenta can go from gorgeous golden to burned very quickly. **Cut** into squares or wedges and serve while hot. Drizzle a little Creamy Tomato Sauce over the polenta and pass the remainder in a bowl on the side.

SERVES 6

chef's note I use Italian fontina cheese here rather than Swiss fontina, which does not melt as smoothly.

